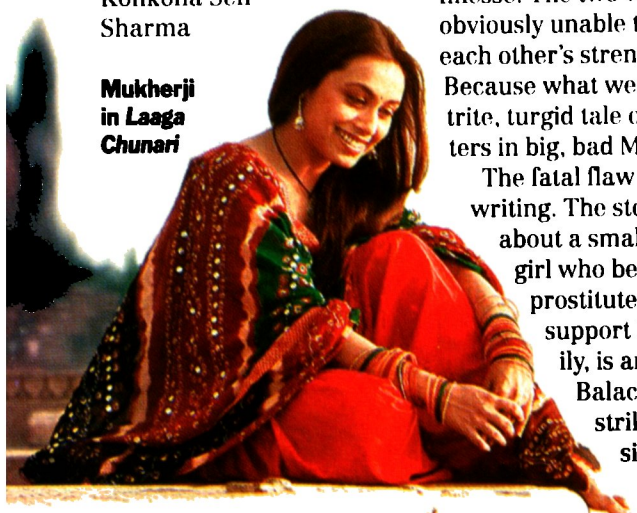


film reviews Turgid Tale

**LAAGA CHUNARI MEIN
DAAG**

Director: Pradeep Sarkar
Starring: Rani Mukherji,
Konkona Sen
Sharma

**Mukherji
in *Laaga
Chunari***



The union of a sensitive and meticulous director like Pradeep Sarkar and a commercially astute producer like Aditya Chopra should have fashioned a blockbuster with substance and finesse. The two were obviously unable to play to each other's strengths. Because what we have is a trite, turgid tale of two sisters in big, bad Mumbai.

The fatal flaw is the writing. The story, about a small-town girl who becomes a prostitute to support her family, is archaic (K. Balachander's strikingly similar *Aaina*

was made 30 years ago). So is its telling. Sarkar is unable to convincingly establish why the elder sister dons high heels and becomes a prostitute—she is aided in this endeavour by a bewildering woman who looks like a fashion model but immediately suggests becoming a high class escort. The other characters—from Jaya Bachchan's spineless mother to Abhishek Bachchan's Prince Charming—are equally unpersuasive.

So despite some genuinely heart-rending scenes, pretty visuals and nuanced performances, *Laaga Chunari* remains still-born.

by Anupama Chopra

festival Perfect Blend

DELHI Over the last three years, The IIC Experience, India International Centre's festival of arts has gained popularity for the right mix of arts, literature and culture. This year relive the experience from October 24-30 at the Fountain Lawns. The festival opens with an Odissi



Manic Mayhem

BHOOL BHULAIYA

Director: Priyadarshan
Starring: Akshay Kumar,
Vidya Balan, Shiney Ahuja

The first principle of good acting is to be able to make an ass of yourself on screen with no self consciousness. In *Bhool Bhulaiya*, Kumar and Co make complete donkeys of themselves, with bells on. Kumar apes an autorickshaw in one scene going brum-brum. Balan plays barking mad in various Bharatnatyam poses and Ahuja strides through a supposedly haunted mansion screaming



COMIC EXPERTS: Kumar and Company laugh out loud hoarsely at everything that moves. Yet this utter madness does not go completely out of control as some of Priyadarshan's work tends to. It's this manic mayhem that sustains this remake of Fazil's

Manichitratazhu. That and Kumar's developing skills at physical comedy, which lulls viewers into believing he could be the world's leading expert in para-normal behaviour.

by Kaverie Bamzai

Bijoyini Sathpathy

ensemble from Protima Bedi's Nrityagram—Ansh. A film festival. Word to Image: The Literary Imagination and Cinema, will showcase foreign and Indian films based on adaptations of literary works like *Oliver Twist* and *The Old Man and the Sea*. For music lovers there will be Hindustani classical recital—Malwa Raag Rang by Vasundhara and Kalapini Komkali and a Carnatic recital by T.M. Krishna. The festival will conclude with Girish Karnad's play, *Nagama-ndala*, directed by Neelam Man Singh Chowdhry.

by S. Sahaya Ranjit

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